

A BRIDGE TOO FAR

As the Railway Ministry wakes up to the "feasibility" issues of the Katra-Qazigund track, it discovers a financial loss and a broken dream to connect the Valley with the rest of the country

■ By Bhavna Vij-Aurora

Nearly a decade after work began on an ambitious plan to connect Kashmir's mountainous villages with the rest of the country by a railway link, it has come apart with Lalu Prasad Yadav's Ministry doing a sudden U-turn and abandoning work on the longest section between Katra and Qazigund. This section is the crucial part of the 346-km railway link. The Jammu-Udhampur section was completed in April 2005. Construction from the other end of the line has also made considerable progress but now it appears that they may never meet since the fate of the major connecting section is in limbo. It seems to have suddenly dawned on the Railway Board that the alignment of the 148 km-stretch is all wrong, and now they propose a relatively shorter (92 km) alternate alignment, based on "toposheet and satellite imageries".

And who do they blame for the loss of Rs 2,000 crore and 10 years of hard work? "It was a political decision. In 2002, prime minister Vajpayee announced that Srinagar will be connected with the rest of the country through a railway line. We were forced to start the work without proper surveys," claims Railway Board Member (Engineering) S.K. Vij. "It was my decision to stop work. For four-and-a-half years that the work on the section has been going on, it is all wrong professionally and from the engineering point of view," he says. His statement is, however, refuted by engineers and experts. "What Vajpayee did was to declare it a national project and ensure that funds would be available. There is no point politicising the issue just because the Railways have messed it up," says an engineer with the project.

S.P.S. Jain and R.R. Jaruhar, who



RED LIGHT: The Baramulla stretch which is now rendered useless